



Well begun is half done: That India managed to retain the title despite all the challenges augurs well. But it didn't come easy and the road ahead will only get tougher for coach Harendra Singh and his girls.

especially China and Japan, the two Asian teams which played in Paris — highlighted India's status as favourites, with enough experience in its ranks, the shadow of eight consecutive losses loomed over the players.

"The makeup of the other team is neither our concern nor our problem. For us, it's about our process and targets, and that's what I have always emphasised. If you focus on your game, you can achieve results. If you get preoccupied with the opponent's game — it's important to plan and strategise, no doubt — you risk losing sight of yourself," Harendra insisted throughout the tournament.

Although the team trained for a

few weeks before the ACT kicked off, the uncertainty of performing in match situations after a five-month hiatus, coupled with reminders of past struggles, was evident early on. India's first match of the tournament, played on the newly-laid turf at the brand-new and barely completed hockey venue at Rajgir Sports Complex, was tentative. **It took a break and some encouraging words from the bench for the girls to regroup and secure a 4-0 win against a much lower-ranked Malaysia.**

There was uncertainty inside the circle and a lack of cohesion and clarity overall. The players appeared

hurried and, at times, unsure of their positioning and plans. "They needed to settle down, calm themselves, and avoid being rushed. Emotional control is something we are constantly working on," Harendra admitted.

The team improved as the tournament progressed. There was a noticeable enhancement in fitness levels and a growing understanding among players and of game situations. By the time India faced China — the toughest competitor besides the host and the top-scoring team in the competition till then, including a 15-0 thrashing of



With a revamped and inexperienced forward line in the absence of veteran Vandana Katariya, everyone had to adapt to new roles and responsibilities.